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Senior Exemption Audit

EXEMPTIONS **CORE**

Decide which senior/disabled exemptions are valid — and defend the calls.

THE PROBLEM

What you're facing

A backlog of senior and disabled-person exemption applications and renewals must be approved, denied, or flagged — each one changes a household's tax bill and the county's levy base.

WHY IT MATTERS

What's at stake

These are real people on fixed incomes, and the program (RCW 84.36.381) is income-tested and audited. Wrong approvals erode the levy base and invite a state audit finding; wrong denials harm the most vulnerable taxpayers and generate appeals.

THE MENTAL MODEL

How experts think

Experts treat it as a three-gate eligibility test, not a form-check: (1) the person — age 61+, or disabled, or a qualifying veteran; (2) the property — owned and occupied as the primary residence on the lien date; (3) the income — combined disposable income below the county-indexed threshold tier. They reconcile the claimed income against what the file actually shows, and they document WHY a borderline case cleared or failed.

Workflow

1. Confirm the qualifying person and relationship to title (life estate, trust, and co-owner cases are where errors hide).
2. Verify primary-residence occupancy on January 1 (the WA assessment/lien date).
3. Compute combined disposable income and place it in the correct threshold tier for the cycle.
4. Reconcile against prior-year exemption status; flag any income jump or property transfer.
5. Record the decision with the specific reason and the evidence relied on.

Common mistakes

- Approving on age alone without testing income or occupancy.
- Missing trust/life-estate ownership nuances that change eligibility.
- Using a stale income threshold from a prior cycle.
- Approving without a written, auditable reason for borderline cases.

Tools

Exemption application + renewal file Income documentation County median income threshold table

Property record (ownership + occupancy)

DO THIS NEXT

Now What?



Forge



Atlas



Dais



Dossier



GPT



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